Shans, Kachins, Chins, Mons, and Arakanese clamored for more autonomy within the separate regions. Fractures occurred throughout the 1950s as the Karens, Mons, and Arakans created separate states. The structure originally established was complicated as the Shan and Karenni were allowed to secede after 10 years but that same right was denied to other ethnic groups. Citizenship rights were limited to people belonging to any of Burma's indigenous groups or with ancestors born in Burma and inhabiting Burmese territory for at least two generations. These measures particularly affected Burma's Chinese, Indian, and Muslim Rohingya populations.

Burma's government was a parliamentary democracy. The president had limited power and was indirectly elected by parliament. The legislature, or Pyithu Hluttaw, was a bicameral system. The lower chamber of deputies was elected by universal suffrage, while the upper chamber of nationalities was divided by ethnic minorities and representatives from territories ruled by the central government. Particular ethnic minority leaders were guaranteed representation in the lower chamber.

The AFPFL dominated the political situation in Myanmar from 1948 to 1958. This control was a legacy of the organization's association with the anticolonial struggle. Many of the early leaders were philosophically socialist, but in the Burmese context this was considerably watered down. Different factions within AFPFL used a patron-client relationship in order to sustain loyalty to the party.

The AFPFL won overwhelming victories in the first two general elections, winning 147 of 239 contested seats. U Nu's rise as the leader following the death of Aung San can be attributed to his honesty and knowledge of the government structure. He seemed determined to end widespread corruption, which led to him gaining significant support in both rural and urban areas.

ECONOMIC POLICY IN POSTINDEPENDENT BURMA

U Nu launched a four-year plan to convert Myanmar into a welfare state. The goals included improvements in education, public health, subsidized housing, easy credit, and debt relief. In addition, U Nu promoted the reallocation of several million acres of farmland to new tenants. The early